THEORY DISCIPLINE

SEMINAR 7

Module Summary & Assessment

19 March 2026

DEADLINE

1,750-word Academic Essay

Due: 24 April 2026 by 5:00 pm | Submitted via Turnitin

For students taking:

FGCT5006 — Games Arts Pathway
FGCT5012 — Performance Animation
FGCT5019 — Games Studio
FGCT5017 — Tools and Production

⚠ *After submitting via Turnitin, confirm submission is complete. If technical issues arise, email your tutor with a copy.*

THE QUESTION

What recent games, media and franchises have informed the development of your practical portfolio? How might these points of inspiration be critically explored and contextualised using academic knowledge and insights into your creative practice?

You might want to consider:

PROCEDURAL RHETORIC	GAMES AS ART	NATURE IN GAMES	WAR GAMES	MONEY GAMES

YOUR ESSAY MUST INCLUDE

01

Reference to your creative project

Connect your essay argument to your own portfolio work.

02

A clear historical or critical framework

Situate your argument within broader game theory and history.

03

At least three appropriate academic sources

Draw from peer-reviewed journals, books, and readings from the module.

04

A bibliography

Include only material you have explicitly referenced in the essay.

05

A 200-word research process section

★ NEW

Detail how you conducted your research — this is a NEW requirement for Term 2.

ESSAY STRUCTURE

01
INTRODUCTION

Set out your argument, introduce your portfolio project, and outline the themes and sources you will use.

02
LITERATURE REVIEW

Engage with your academic sources. Summarise the key debates and theories relevant to your topic — procedural rhetoric, art, nature, war, or money.

03
CASE STUDIES

Analyse specific games and media using the theoretical frameworks. Include your own creative practice as a case study.

04
CONCLUSION

Draw together your argument. What have your case studies revealed? What critical insight can you offer about games and your practice?

WHAT WE'VE COVERED

SESSION 2 **PROCEDURAL RHETORIC**	Ian Bogost · Serious Games · Gamification · Ideological critique of game mechanics
SESSION 3 **GAMES AS ART**	Roger Ebert · Journey · Flower · Art games · Cultural legitimacy of the medium
SESSION 4 **NATURE IN GAMES**	Thoreau · Pastoral fantasy · Urban/wilderness binary · Game landscapes & ecology
SESSION 5 **WAR GAMES**	Military-entertainment complex · Drone warfare · Full Spectrum Warrior · Moral quagmire
SESSION 6 **MONEY GAMES**	Microtransactions · Free-to-play · Digital distribution · Attention economy

SESSION 2

PROCEDURAL RHETORIC

Ian Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric argues that games communicate ideological arguments through their mechanics, not just their visuals or narratives. Games make claims about how the world works by the rules they enforce.

Key debates:

What is a 'serious game' and does the label help or hurt?

Can game mechanics themselves carry ideological meaning?

How has gamification been used (and misused) beyond games?

KEY SOURCE

Bogost, I. (2007)
Persuasive Games:
The Expressive Power
of Videogames.
MIT Press.

(pp. 1–3, 20–21, 29–34)

Essay link

How do your game mechanics communicate ideas? What arguments does your portfolio project make through its design?

SESSION 3

GAMES AS ART

Film critic Roger Ebert famously declared "video games can never be art." The games community pushed back fiercely. Titles such as Journey and Flower became touchstones in arguments for games as culturally legitimate artistic works — but does being called 'art' change what a game is?

Questions to consider:

Which games qualify as art, and by whose criteria?

Can a triple-A commercial title also be art?

Is pursuing 'art' status even a productive goal for games?

How do institutional definitions of art apply to interactive media?

KEY SOURCE

Jenkins, H. (2007)
'Games, the New
Lively Art'
In: The WOW Climax.
NYU Press.
(pp. 19–40)

Essay link

Does your portfolio project aspire to artistic expression? How does it relate to game art debates?

SESSION 4

NATURE IN GAMES

When Henry Thoreau retreated to the woods to escape urban life, he was enacting a cultural myth of 'nature' as remedy. Games reproduce this myth obsessively — from Hyrule Field to Minecraft's procedural wilderness. But 'nature' in games is never neutral. It reflects ideology, history, and how we understand the non-human world.

Questions to consider:

Why are games so committed to an urban/wilderness binary?

What does the pastoral fantasy in games tell us about ourselves?

How does Minecraft's landscape encode neoliberal assumptions?

What does 'ecology' in games mean beyond just green textures?

KEY SOURCE

Chang, A.Y. (2019)
'Introduction:
Edge Effects'
In: Playing Nature.
Minnesota
University Press.

Essay link

Does your project feature natural environments or landscapes? What assumptions about nature does it encode?

SESSION 5

WAR GAMES

Predator drone pilots use adapted PlayStation controllers. The US Military funds civilian game-engine development. Video games were born in military research labs. The military-entertainment complex has shaped games from their origins — and games have shaped how we imagine, train for, and feel about war.

Questions to consider:

How does military funding shape the games industry?

What does it mean that war is the most common game genre?

How do war games normalise or critique military violence?

As designers and consumers — what is our moral responsibility?

KEY SOURCE

Dyer-Witheford &
de Peuter (2009)
'Banal War:
Full Spectrum
Warrior'
In: Games of Empire.
Minnesota Press.
(pp. 97–122)

Essay link

Does your portfolio engage with conflict, violence or military themes? How does it position the player morally?

SESSION 6

MONEY GAMES

Games are commodities. With Steam, digital distribution, microtransactions and free-to-play, the relationship between players and money has been radically transformed. Many developers now prioritise capturing attention through psychological manipulation, then monetising the compulsion that follows.

Questions to consider:

How has digital distribution changed the commodity form of games?

What psychological mechanisms do free-to-play games exploit?

What moral responsibilities do developers have around monetisation?

How do loot boxes, battle passes, and skins relate to gambling?

KEY SOURCE

Evans, E. (2016) 'The economics of free: Freemium games, branding and the impatience economy' Convergence, 22(6).

Essay link

Does your project have a business model? What does it reveal about games, commerce and player attention?

WRITING YOUR ESSAY

ARGUE, DON'T DESCRIBE

Academic essays make an argument. Don't simply summarise games or theories, use them as evidence for a position.

USE YOUR SOURCES PROPERLY

Quote and paraphrase from academic texts. Engage with the ideas, not just the names. Avoid dropping references without analysis.

CONNECT TO YOUR PRACTICE

Your portfolio is not a footnote, it is a case study. Treat your own work with the same critical rigour as any other game.

INCLUDE THE RESEARCH PROCESS

★ NEW

A new Term 2 requirement: add a 200-word section describing how you found and selected your sources.

GOOD LUCK.

DEADLINE

24 April 2026 — 5:00 pm

Submit via Turnitin · Confirm submission · Email if technical issues arise

Final checklist:

1,750 words · Academic essay format
Reference to your creative project / portfolio
Clear historical or critical framework
At least three appropriate academic sources
Bibliography of explicitly referenced works only
200-word research process section (new for Term 2)